Check My Chest (Am I Still Breathing?)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48210223.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Fandom:
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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Part 2 of Love You Until The Day I Die (And Then Do It Again)

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Summary

In an immortal love, there's too many stories to tell to stop at one, even for just one life. Catra and Adora have found each other across death and now they face down their eternity together, hand-in-hand.
(Or, flashes in the pan in the reincarnation-verse. Follow-up to "Trade Today For Tomorrow")

Notes

This is not a standalone fic!It's snippets and side stories from the one shot (stretching that term to its limit) Trade Today For Tomorrow. It's probably completely incoherent without that. This fic is non-linear.

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra's social media is full of pictures of her smiling.

Adora cant remember the last time she saw Catra genuinely smile. It was definitely more than thirty years ago. She scrolls through the pictures, watching Catra's age regress as she does. She's young enough it's noticeable in the few short years she has had the page.

Young. Adora thought about finding her again. She pictured an older woman – she hesitates to say *just* old because that would mean they didnt have much time left – with wrinkles around her eyes, gray-flecked fur, and thick claws showing her age. She *hoped* she would have laughter lines, at least – that Catra went on to find happiness, as much as it hurt to think of her moving on and remarrying. She wanted Catra to be happy even if they werent together . Every day she wasnt there felt like one lost. She knew since she was a teenager that she wanted to be with Catra for the rest of her life. Seeing someone else in that role would have hurt, but not as much as seeing Catra miserable, consumed by depression and anxiety , did.

When she saw the mismatched eyes on the street, her stomach bottomed out. She was Catra's spitting image, and her mind only went to one thing: Catra had a daughter. That *hurt*. She hadnt just moved on, she had settled down with someone else in a way she and Adora were never going to. They had two conversations, both brief, about kids.

One was before they got together, when they were teenagers. It amounted to, "I hate kids, I never want one," and Adora giggling before admitting that she thought they were cute, but she was never going to have one.

"It' s not guaranteed to pass down," was all she needed to say on that topic and they both understood why she never wanted to have a child. Outliving it would hurt – maybe be impossible. They had a similar conversation several years later, when they were married,

and still happy, and a few people had asked them what their plans were.

"I dont want them. Seems like a lot of work," Catra said, flashing Adora a cheeky smile at the end. Adora just nodded, relieved, because her answer hadnt changed.

Seeing that magicat on the street, she thought, *oh, she lied*. Of course she said she didnt want them when Adora was her wife, she didnt want her to feel bad about holding her back from them.

But it wasnt her daughter , and she didnt move on, and she isnt an old woman. Instead, her social media is filled with pictures of the city and her moving around it, and as Adora scrolls back further, the exact same photos only set in beautiful gardens, cozy houses, and some fancy buildings Adora has to imagine are the temple Catra mentioned. She thinks she can pick out Catra's home in the shots, though, certain backgrounds appearing most frequently . One of her moms must be a gardener. Catra takes a lot of pictures in front of some beautifully cared for carnation bushes.

She takes photos with her moms too, all three of them beaming happily. It's like a peek into the life they should have had. It's not a mirage, though. Catra actually *got* it.

She deserves it. Seeing even this carefully curated slice of it, Adora can see how the Catra she lost became the one who found her again.

It gives her hope. This time, love might just be enough.

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"Are you nervous to present?"

Contrary to popular belief, Catra doesnt eavesdrop, it kind of just happens. She was wondering whose presentation she was going to have to sit through for today's class – the first of three where everyone does their final project presentations – though, so she flicks her ear back and pays attention to the response.

"Yeah. It's kind of a weird topic."

"Oh, you got the Fright Zone, right?"

"Yeah, and I definitely figured out why it was called that looking into its city planning history. The rules there were so strict. Every rigid societal stereotype you can think of defined that place in the 60s. It's one of those things you cant imagine existing now. Walking through there must have looked like utopia at the time, but it's just dystopia now."

Ugh. Catra flicks her ear forward again. She's going to have to listen to this idiot talk about Fright Zone city planning for twenty minutes? He clearly doesnt know the first thing about what those codes amounted to. She pulls out her notebook and decides this class is going to be spent doodling. It will be pretty obvious what she's doing since she doubts anyone else will be taking notes on the presentations, but it will keep her sane.

Normally her classes are pretty good. Jumping from *mechanic* to *mechanical engineer* means it's all new material, even the gen eds since she never went to college in her last life. The hard part is when recent history stuff comes up, a few decades back so people are stupid about it but recent enough for Catra to remember the lasting effects of it, if not the event itself.

Mostly, she just lives as a nineteen-year-old. Some of her friends she keeps up with from past classes know how old she is, and her coworkers do considering she used her past-life experience to get her current job, but classmates might as well be strangers. Most likely they wouldnt even believe her and she doesnt want to be treated like a freak even if she cared to bother.

Usually. Usually she isn't ten minutes into a presentation with glaring holes. When Dylan – a fresh-faced human, still with his teenage acne, clearly a regular mortal – clicks onto a slide with another stupid picture and continues to prattle on about the *delicate sensibilities* of the time, Catra can't take it anymore. She throws her hand up even though they aren't to the part where people are supposed to ask questions. Dylan blinks at her , glancing at the teacher, who nods. He points to her.

"Yes, uh, Catra?" It's kind of shocking it took him a minute to remember her name considering she's the only magicat in the class.

"This is the third photo of the exact same street at a different angle you've shown to supposedly demonstrate the homogeny of the city design and culture. All your photos have either been taken from the factory district or from the same four block radius in the swanky part of town. These buildings are decades older than the city standards you're reporting on and don't at all represent what the majority of the city looked like," Catra corrects, looking at the photo with disgust for a moment before she drops her gaze back to her sketch. There's a moment of silence following her words.

The teacher clears her throat.

"If you've done your own research, you should let your classmates finish their presentations before presenting *constructive* critiques," she says, her tone relatively neutral. Catra bites back a snort. Yeah, sure, *her own research*. The teacher turns her chair, facing back to Dylan.

"That said, it is important to check details like this for both your academic pursuits and future professional ones. That's not a critique for the presentation, but for the accuracy of the paper you will submit. It's better to not include a photo than one that is incorrect," she says. Catra's tail flicks, feeling at least a little vindicated. From the front of the room, Dylan waffles for a moment.

"This is what' s available. Most photos are from the civil unrest movements in the 80s. They were taken after people stopped ascribing to restrictive social norms and the standards were loosened," Dylan says, trying to save face. Catra growls under her breath, immediately drawing attention to herself, but she bites her tongue and returns to sketching the bar where ticketers used to come around and always left still holding their papers, too afraid to fine the butch who owned the place. Her biceps were bigger than their heads, so she got away with having her "obscene" signs and red-painted door.

The standards were loosened *because* of the riots. Photos from them would actually depict the buildings built during the time he is covering. If he looked at them, he would see the city was a thousand things, but homogeneous was never one of them. He isn't reporting on a strict city culture, just a few rich bureaucrats who decided how everybody else should live and *lost*.

The Fright Zone was rebellion on every street. It was often dingy from the factory smoke, but people would cover the soot-soaked building faces with flags representing who they were and where they came from. When the cops drove by, they would tear them down before they could confiscate them and then put them right back up once they were gone. All those ordinances just gave them something to fight. Is it too much to ask that people remember *that* instead of the philosophies of the rich few that tried to rule them?

--

Adora runs her finger along the slight indent where her ring should be, waiting for the sales assistant to come back and wondering if they can even begin to imagine what a precious thing they're holding. A lot of people care about their wedding rings, true, but this is so much more than even that. This is a tie that crossed lifetimes.

This is the only proof she had for decades that Catra loved her once. This is something a different kind of vow is hinged on now. It's not just a golden ring.

They come back to her with a selection of four rings spread out in a row on a small jewelry display box with another six engagement rings beneath it, her ring relegated to the corner. Quickly, Adora snatches it back up.

"We don't have a ring that is an exact match to your wedding band in every way, but these are the closest we have," he explains. Adora feels her heart fall a little, but she nods and lets him walk her through the options.

The gold is wrong on two of them. She immediately rejects them. The third is visibly narrower than hers. The fourth looks okay from the top, but its sides are far more curved than the subtle slope on hers. Adora sighs, disappointed, as she shakes her head and puts the rings back.

"I'm sorry, they need to be closer. It needs to feel and look the same when she wears it. I know the engagement ring can't be matched that well, but these are too different, also," Adora says, already mentally planning how she's going to fit in another secret trip to the fourth jeweler on her list. She has been taking them while Catra goes to her evening class, but that doesn't give her a lot of time to reach the jeweler, compare their rings, and then return in time for Catra to never know she left.

"I understand. It's difficult to replace a lost ring when you don't know who made it. May I suggest returning the last jeweler and seeing if they have a record of the order?" he says. Adora huffs a laugh, running her thumb over the ring and comforting herself with its presence. He's just trying to help—genuinely help, not just make a sale—but that's not an option.

"They were in the Fright Zone," she explains. All she said was that her wife lost her rings and she's looking for a replacement. There's

no need to go into more detail that. For the engagement ring especially, it would be great if she had more to go on than her memory and the description she can give of it, but she already googled what she remembered the jeweler's name being and came up with nothing.

"Ah, I see," the way he says it also carries an air of *I see what happened* to it. He's probably assuming she was mugged. That's fine. The Fright Zone has a reputation and it's partially earned. Assuming a mugging only makes since if it happened after they moved to *Bright Moon*, but whatever. "Calling them, then?" he suggests.

"Pretty sure they're not in business anymore. We bought them over thirty years ago," Adora explains. She watches his mouth fall open in a silent *o*. She shrugs, sending him a smile that she hopes communicates *it's okay you assumed*. Why wouldn't he? There's no moonlight right now to betray Adora's –potential– real age.

"Thanks for your help," she tells him, and he does his best to recover, saying he's sorry he couldn't do more and good luck with her search.

She leaves no closer to her goal, but no less determined, either. She'll find something close enough eventually.

--

Catra is trying to find a textbook she used in undergrad that she *swears* explains this concept better than her current one when she spots it. For a moment, she doesn't think anything of it. A ring box, buried on the back of a shelf. Weird Adora stuck it behind some books, but Adora tends to be a mess, so it's honestly not that

surprising. Catra is already checking the next shelf when her brain starts catching up with itself.

The box looked black. It was in shadow, though, and the blue was fading last time she saw it. That's probably all it was. Somehow all the lint had been picked free from its flocking, something Adora didn't even manage when she first presented it to her, but maybe that's how it ended up on the shelf. Adora was walking around trying to pick it clean and then just set it down and forgot about it.

She *swears* their old ring box is still in Adora's bedside table, though, and something about the shape was off. Slowly, she reaches back up to the shelf and pulls the shorter books away that were hiding the ring behind them.

Definitely black. Not even flocked. *Definitely not the box she's used to*. Catra swallows, staring at it.

Her hands shake. She quickly puts back the books. Then it covers up the box and she pulls them away to look at it again.

She shouldn't look, right? No, she should, so she doesn't panic over nothing if it turns out to just be. Okay, she can't come up with something else for it to be, but it doesn't have to be what she's assuming it is. Maybe Adora is holding onto it for Glimmer or something! She should definitely have told Catra so this *exact thing* doesn't happen if that's the case, but she's Adora. It probably didn't occur to her.

The box sits there, unassuming in squared-off leather design. The more she looks at it, the more it's obvious that it absolutely isn't Adora's old one. It's a little big for a ring box, right? Weirdly rectangular?

It's fine. It's a present for *someone* and not a ring. Probably a necklace or something.

Catra puts the books back and decides her textbook definitely isn't here. Instead of looking for it elsewhere, she walks out to the balcony instead, dropping herself down on the bench they replaced two of the chairs with so it's easier to cuddle. She stares up at the sky, her mind buzzing.

Adora has been wearing her ring again for over a year now, but they've only had one conversation about it. Said conversation amounted to Catra staring at her hand for a really long before Adora noticed and took pity on her. She put a hand on her knee, finally breaking Catra's long staring match with the glinting metal. Catra met her eyes, ears pinned back and embarrassed.

"I want to be with you forever, but I'm not ready for another wedding yet," was all she needed to say and Catra relaxed, nodding and accepting it. Adora is wearing her ring, and she means it, but there's a lot of trauma still clinging on to their divorce, so the whole process of getting married would be too much right now. Catra is happy with Adora wearing the ring, marked for her, even if sometimes she looks at it and mourns its lost twin.

Is Adora ready? They've been together again for two and a half years now – closer to three, actually. It both seems fast and like long enough to Catra. Long enough because they already consider themselves dedicated like that and only the paper is missing, but too soon because of everything that went wrong before. They would have a real wedding, this time, not just a small group of friends at the courthouse and a joyous night with them at the bar. They have more friends now, more money, and most importantly, Catra's family. A wedding should be for the couple, but as one half of the couple, Catra wants to see how happy a real wedding would make her moms. That's a *lot*. A lot to deal with, a lot of missed opportunities to grapple with.

Catra thinks she's ready, but she's not the one who left. She expected Adora to take longer. She honestly thought they might be thirty again before it happened. The box could just be nothing and all

these thoughts could be for nothing, but she cant stop herself from wondering: could this really be it?

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Adora is terrible at surprises and she cant think of a good reason to be insisting they go out on this *particular* day in May to celebrate the end of the semester, but Catra agrees with just some confused looks. She doesnt think it's so weird she wants to celebrate Catra surviving her second year of grad school. She's pretty sure they did something last year too, but that was a double date with Glimmer and Bow. It was a pretty informal thing. Now Adora chooses a fancy restaurant, the kind of place they couldnt afford to go in their last life.

The first time, Adora proposed to Catra in their kitchen and it delighted her. Even now, she isnt sure about doing it in public, so she has arranged secret plans with Glimmer and Bow. She swears she catches a suspicious look from Catra during dinner, but after Adora manages to make her knee stop jttering, the conversation returns and their date continues as it usually does. It's a good night. They decide the food was a little overpriced, but it's still fun, especially figuring out what it is when it comes in small treat-sized portions. Catra has a glass of wine at dinner, not even enough to put a flush in her cheeks, and Adora drinks water while making it clear it's just because she's driving them.

She does *not* need to be drunk while proposing. Even one glass of wine is dangerous.

When they go to leave, Catra hesitates before taking her hand, but she lets Adora lead her out to the car. The after-dinner conversation is light and easy and part of Adora is afraid of saying anything to ruin the anniversary of Adora putting her ring on again, but she's pretty sure Catra doesnt even know what day it is so it's a dumb thing to

worry about. There's no going back, anyway, when she opens their front door and Catra sees the flowers and electric candles Bow and Glimmer set up while they were gone. The lights in the main space are off, although the one spilling from the hall helps illuminate where the falsely-flickering candles are failing to give Adora enough clarity.

Catra's eyes flicker over the scene, her pupils blowing out as Adora places a hand on her lower back and guides her out towards the balcony. The bench and chair that are usually out there have been shoved aside, leaving enough room for some more candles and flowers – and for Adora to take Catra's hand and drop to her knee once outside, the city sprawling below them and the moon shining down. Adora's hair glows when the light breeze stirs it into her vision.

Catra looks down at her, eyes wide and breath catching as Adora reaches into her jacket and pulls out the box. When Catra's eyes land on it, Adora is surprised by the recognition she sees there. Obviously Catra would be onto her at this point, the candles and flowers aren't subtle, but there's more to her look.

"Alright, how long have you known?" Adora asks, shaking her head and smiling to herself as she drops Catra's hand so both her hands are ready to open the box. Honestly, Catra has been onto her since at least the restaurant.

"I found it a few months ago. I didn't look. I'd convinced myself it was something you were hiding for Bow by now," Catra admits, a warm smile blossoming on her face. Her eyes don't leave the box.

"Shoulda thought of that," Adora whispers to herself, earning a laugh from Catra that crinkles the corners of her eyes. Adora is smiling herself as she finally cracks the box open.

Immediately, Catra gasps. Adora's smile turns a bit nervous as she raises from her knee so Catra can get a better look at it. Adora glances down at the two rings sitting on the pillow inside, the engagement ring settled closer to Catra while the wedding ring is further up on the cushion.

I wanted to find the closest thing that I could to what we had before. I didn't want you to feel like you had lost it – lost *us*. We went through hard times, but finding you again has brought me back all that happiness we once had. I don't want us to hold back because of old fears anymore. I want you to look down at your hand and know I want you forever, so Catra, will you be my wife again?" Adora asks, voice breathless from hope and nerves. She doesn't think Catra will say *no*, but it's possible that she isn't ready yet. They can take as long as they need, but Adora is pretty sure they have been waiting on her. She's ready. She wants to have this again.

Catra's breathing is shaking as she stares down at the rings, still unable to look away from them for a long moment. Adora suddenly worries that she messed this up and Catra *wanted* a clean slate. Finally, Catra rips her eyes from the pillow to meet Adora's gaze.

"*Yes*, I will," she agrees. Relief breaks over Adora like a wave, tears suddenly hitting her eyes. Catra shares them, looking down at the rings again. Quickly, Adora hurries to take the engagement ring off the pillow, holding it out for Catra. *Both* their hands are shaking, so it takes Adora two tries to get it on her finger, but slowly she slides it down. Catra swallows, lifting her hand closer to her face to stare at it.

"They, um, make diamonds bigger than they used to," Adora jokes. Catra lets out a wet laugh, looking up to send Adora a smile.

"Dummy," she accuses, shaking her head a little and reaching up with her free hand to wipe at the corner of her eye. Adora smiles, suddenly feeling light.

"I did my best with the engagement ring. You deserve one that's a little nicer now we can afford it, anyway. The wedding ring... That was easier to make sure was the same. And harder, because I could see all the differences right away, but I finally found one that matched," Adora says, lifting the band from the pillow and holding it in the palm of her left hand so Catra can see it beside the one of Adora's finger. Catra's gaze follows the movement, a soft *oh* escaping her when Adora lays it out.

She reaches out, her fingers tracing over the curve of the band for a lingering moment. When she pulls her hand back, it's to reach for the engagement ring on her finger instead, tracing it, too.

"Adora, *thank you*. For this, and for trying so hard, and for wanting to marry me again, and for- for just *being* and letting me fix my mistakes," Catra manages, raising a hand to her face when tears nearly break through at the end. Quickly, Adora slides the weddingring back into place and clicks the lid shut so she has the free hands to reach for Catra.

"Thank you for wanting to try again. Thank you for coming back. I love you, Catra. I'm so lucky to get to do it again," Adora says, lightly pulling Catra's hand back down from her face so she can brush away the tear that escapes. Adora wraps her arm still holding the ring box around Catra's back, pulling her close. Catra lets out a small sob, tucking her left hand close to her chest as if to keep the engagement ring close to her heart –safe– and wrapping her other arm around Adora to hug her back.

"I love you. I love you so much. I want to be your wife again," Catra says into her shoulder, on the verge of tears. Well, the verge of sobbing. She's definitely getting tears on Adora's suit, but Adora's own eyes are misty, so she can't say anything. She would never complain about Catra in her arms.

"You're always going to be my everything," Adora promises her, pressing a kiss against her ear and definitely getting it wet in the process. Catra does release a sob then. For a minute, both of them just let the emotions take them, clinging to each other and silently crying. Slowly, Adora begins to blink the tears away. Catra gets it together sooner than she does, letting out a controlled breath and pulling back.

Ok, apparently she just needed to see the ring again because she's actually still crying a little as she unfurls her hand between their chests and admires it with awe, her pupils dilated. Adora reaches up,

brushing Catra's tears away when they well over. Catra looks up, offering Adora a watery smile.

"You realize this means we need to have a big wedding, right? My moms would kill us if we didn't," she jokes. Adora genuinely laughs, the last tears squeezing out when her eyes crickle.

"I know . I can't wait," she promises. Catra releases a soft breath, looking up at her with the same blatant awe she admired the ring with. Then, slowly, a smile like the sun breaks over her face. Something that could be a laugh or could be a hiccupping sob rises in her chest and she lifts a hand as if to cover her smile, but a beautiful joy dances in her eyes.

"I can't wait, either ," Catra says, and then she's throwing herself forward into Adora's arms again. Adora hugs her back, the ring box awkwardly pressed into her shoulder, but Catra doesn't seem to care.

They're getting married again. That's all that matters. They're together, for all eternity. When they say those vows this time, they'll hold more weight than they ever could for mortals.

They'll mean every word.

End Notes

Title is from Until The Day I Die by Morgan Saint.
Fic notes for this series are up on my tumblr. If I ever decide to continue this verse, it will be in this fic, so subscribe if you want (not making any promises, it's just something I *could* see happening.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!